

Career Program Framework

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This document is the governing constitution of a personal strategic management system. It defines the structure, purpose, and operating principles of the system before any content is populated. Every strategic decision, planning artifact, and review cadence that follows derives its authority from what is written here. When content and structure are in conflict, structure governs. When execution and strategy are in conflict, this document provides the mechanism for resolution.

The system is modeled on program management principles and adapted from Hoshin Kanri strategy deployment. It is designed for one purpose: sustained, intentional career development over a multi-year horizon, executed with the same rigor applied to consequential professional programs.

1 Governing Principle

Every element in the framework must trace to a parent. An action item without an initiative, an initiative without an annual objective, or an annual objective without a breakthrough goal has no place in the plan. If the line cannot be drawn, the element is either misplaced or the plan has a gap.

2 Structure

The framework has three layers. Each layer has a distinct purpose, operates at a different time horizon, and demands a different level of granularity. Information flows upward through the layers via the performance cadence. Decisions flow downward — strategy informs the operating model, the operating model informs daily action.

2.1 Layer 1 — Strategic Foundation

Purpose: Define where you are going and why you will win there.

The anchor document. This layer operates at the level of enduring truth — statements that should remain stable across the full planning horizon and require deliberate annual review before they are changed. Content here is not aspirational language. It is the considered output of rigorous self-assessment and strategic analysis. If it cannot be defended, it should not be written.

Granularity standard: Layer 1 content is general enough to survive role changes, company changes, and market shifts without becoming false. It is specific enough that someone who read it could not mistake it for belonging to a different person. Generic statements that could describe any senior professional are insufficient.

Contents:

- Personal mission — a single statement answering why this direction, in your own words. Not a tagline. The test is whether it remains true in five years regardless of which specific role or company you are in.
- Positioning thesis — the competitive argument for why you specifically win in your target functions. Grounded in specific evidence from your career history. Not what you want to be known for — what you can actually demonstrate.
- Target functions — defined roles with entry angles, competitive rationale, and sequencing logic. Specific enough to guide targeting decisions but not so narrow as to preclude adjacent opportunities.
- Known gaps — an honest, unvarnished assessment of what stands between current state and target state. Gaps are not weaknesses to be minimized. They are the primary inputs to Layer 2.
- Breakthrough goals — 3 to 5 statements defining success at the 5-year horizon. Written as conditions, not activities. The test of a breakthrough goal is whether you would unambiguously know if you had achieved it.

2.2 Layer 2 — Operating Model

Purpose: Translate strategy into an executable, milestone-gated plan.

The living roadmap. This layer operates at the level of committed plans — specific enough to be executed, flexible enough to be updated when Layer 3 surfaces a signal. Content here bridges the enduring truth of Layer 1 and the weekly reality of Layer 3. It is where strategy becomes work.

Granularity standard: Layer 2 content is specific enough that completion can be assessed without judgment. Each initiative has a definition of done. Each action item is discrete and ownable. Vague entries such as “build network” are insufficient — they must be decomposed until they are actionable.

Node hierarchy:

- Breakthrough goal (Layer 1 parent)
 - Annual objective — what must be true by year end to be on track toward the breakthrough goal
 - * Initiative — the workstream or project that achieves the annual objective
 - Action item — the discrete, completable unit of work that advances the initiative

Each initiative has a definition of done and a target timeframe. Each phase has a named gate — a condition, not just a date, that determines readiness to advance.

2.3 Layer 3 — Performance Cadence

Purpose: Surface signals, drive accountability, and trigger updates to Layer 2.

The operating rhythm. This layer functions at the level of honest observation — what actually happened versus what was committed to, and what that pattern means. Content here is not polished. It is a truthful log of commitments, completions, and reflections. Its value compounds over time as patterns become visible.

Granularity standard: Layer 3 entries are specific and dated. Generalizations are not useful here. The weekly log records actual actions, not intentions. The monthly reflection names specific misalignments, not general impressions. The quarterly review renders a judgment on whether the strategy is working, supported by observable evidence.

The four loops:

- **Weekly — Did I do what I committed to?** Track actions committed versus actions completed. No strategy discussion. The purpose is building the habit of honoring commitments to yourself and identifying where friction actually lives.
- **Monthly — Are my activities aligned to my priorities?** Look at the pattern across weeks. If a priority appears in Layer 2 but no actions trace to it in the past month, that is a signal. Assess whether the misalignment is a motivation problem, a sequencing problem, or a strategy problem.
- **Quarterly — Is my positioning working?** This is where leading indicators are assessed. Are the right people finding you? Are conversations happening with the right functions at the right companies? Are capability gaps closing? This is also where Layer 2 is formally reviewed and updated if needed.
- **Annually — Is the strategy itself still correct?** Revisit Layer 1. Markets shift, opportunities emerge, priorities clarify. The annual review asks whether the positioning thesis, target functions, and breakthrough goals still hold — and revises the strategic foundation if they do not.

3 The Correction Mechanism

When the cadence surfaces a signal, a judgment is required before acting on it.

Execution problem: the strategy is correct but actions are not being completed, initiatives are stalled, or milestones are slipping. Response: update Layer 2. Resequence, rescope, or recommit at the action item or initiative level.

Strategy problem: actions are being completed but leading indicators are not moving, or external conditions have materially changed. Response: flag for the annual review. Do not reactively update Layer 1 mid-cycle except under significant circumstances.

This distinction prevents two failure modes: the rigid plan that never adapts, and the reactive plan that never holds still long enough to generate signal.

4 How Layer 1 Is Populated

Layer 1 is not completed in a single sitting. Each element requires a different type of thinking and a different input.

Personal mission is developed through directed reflection — examining what work genuinely energizes, what type of problem demands your best thinking, what the satisfaction of good work actually feels like, and why that matters personally. It is not drafted from a template. It is arrived at through honest interrogation of those questions until the answer is specific enough to be yours and stable enough to survive time.

Positioning thesis is built from three components that must work together: differentiated capability, evidence base, and target context. It is drafted only after the competitive landscape of the target functions has been examined. The thesis makes an additive argument, not a comparative one. It does not define you by what others lack.

Target functions are defined with three elements: a functional description grounded in how the role actually operates at a large prime, an entry angle that is honest about the credible path given current positioning, and a time horizon that reflects sequencing logic rather than aspiration. Functions are pruned until the list is coherent and executable.

Known gaps are assessed in three stages corresponding to the three time horizons of the target functions. Near-term gaps are assessed in detail across two dimensions: competency gaps — the analytical, financial, and professional capabilities required to perform in the target function — and positioning gaps — the visibility, credentialing, and network conditions required to be considered for it. Competency gaps are named first because execution of the mission depends on the quality of the work, not the quality of the positioning. Medium-term gaps are assessed directionally. Long-term gaps are noted at a high level and revisited at each annual review.

Breakthrough goals are written last, after the preceding elements have been established. They are written as conditions, not activities. Each must trace directly to the personal mission and positioning thesis, and each must have at least one annual objective in Layer 2 that traces back to it.

5 Relationship to Existing Frameworks

This framework draws deliberately from three sources.

Hoshin Kanri provides the core logic: a strategic foundation that stays stable, an operating model that executes it, and a cadence that surfaces feedback and drives course correction. The catchball concept — information flowing upward, decisions flowing downward — is the structural backbone.

Program management provides the phase-gate structure and the discipline of defining done before beginning. Each phase in Layer 2 has a gate, not just a timeline.

The personal work breakdown structure provides the node hierarchy in

Layer 2. Every action item traces to an initiative, every initiative to an annual objective, every annual objective to a breakthrough goal. Anything that cannot be traced does not belong in the plan.

6 What This Framework Is Not

It is not a to-do list. Action items are the lowest node in a strategic hierarchy, not the starting point.

It is not a goal-setting exercise. Breakthrough goals without an operating model and a cadence are wishes.

It is not static. The correction mechanism is not a failure mode — it is the intended behavior of a living system.

It is not a performance evaluation. The cadence is a tool for self-directed accountability, not judgment.